agenda itself is undergoing a change, reflecting more diverse interests than before. The outcomes of key negotiations, such as the Paris climate change accord, also reflect this changed reality. So too do the creation of new institutions like the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank or the International Solar Alliance. The demand for fairer representation in bodies like the IMF and the continued pressure for UN reform are other such manifestations. China is the great disrupter here since unlike Japan, South Korea or the ASEAN, its emergence cannot be accommodated in the old framework. The rise of India will only reinforce this pressure for change. For all their other differences, the demand for a more contemporary global order does put India and China on the same side of the table.

A second driver of greater nationalism is its very opposite: the reaction in more privileged societies to this rebalancing. The offshoring of manufacturing and creation of extensive global supply chains has inevitably had an impact on the West. The consequent resentment has been aggravated by a perception that some have taken unfair advantage of the global trading system. As immigrant flows expand, they too contribute to a sense of loss of power in certain income groups. Ironically, the immediate crisis in Europe was sparked less by these happenings and more by refugees from conflict situations for which the West itself has responsibility. Be that as it may, the outcome has still been a hybrid economic-cultural protectionism which has found traction in political opinion.

A third category is the accumulated impact of how sharper cultural identities across the world have played on each other. The epicentre for that has been West Asia; and other regions have reacted to it over time. While the cause and effect of this process can always be debated, the fact is that there is a change in how people define themselves and perceive others. As a result, many of the broader identity constructs have come under challenge. As these trends fuse, the balance between economics, politics, culture, faith and identity has been disturbed. This will obviously vary from country to country and have its own dynamics. We should expect uneasy coexistence and shifting equations between globalist and nationalist forces as neither can prevail. And the world it will produce will be very contentious.